



4-12-2022 MCS Board Meeting

Meeting Metadata	Details
Video Recording	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=zgdr0Fun_fs
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Community Meeting Report: Municipal & School Board Session

Meeting Date: April 12, 2022 (*inferred from agenda publication dates*)

Body: Muncie Community Schools Board of Trustees

Report Prepared By: Expert Civic Analyst

1. Pre-Meeting Hearings & Committee Work Sessions

No statutory public hearing or committee work session was held immediately prior to the call to order.

2. Meeting Identification & Attendance

- **Call to Order & Spoken Details:** The meeting was called to order by the presiding officer. Opening procedures included a moment of silence and the Pledge of Allegiance.
- **Attendance:**
 - **Present:** Dave Heater, Dr. Bales, Mr. Irvin, Mr. Lowe, Ratasha Barnes Griffin, Leanne Gudgel.

- **Absent:** Board President Jim Williams (noted as recovering from a medical procedure).
 - **Presiding Officer:** Vice President / Acting Chair (Board President Jim Williams absent).
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3. Preliminary & Procedural Business

- **Ceremonial Openings:** The Pledge of Allegiance was led by the board, noting no visiting students were present for the opening pledge.
 - **Approval of Minutes:** *[Not explicitly detailed in the transcript text.]*
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4. Substantive Business & Board Action

- **00:04:22 Guest Presentation by Muncie Mayor Dan Ridenauer: TIF Districts & Community Partnerships**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Mayor Dan Ridenauer.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Mayor Ridenauer presented an overview of Tax Increment Financing (TIF) districts and announced that six major upcoming economic development and housing projects totaling roughly \$45 million in value will **not** be placed inside TIF allocation areas. This decision allows increased property tax revenues to flow directly into the city's general fund and the Muncie Community Schools (MCS) operating fund, estimated to generate approximately \$6.2 million in added revenue over 18 years. Projects discussed included Store Estates (34 single-family lots and a park), City View Homes (phases 1 and 2, adding ~84 housing units), the former downtown jail condo conversion, Markets on Madison (Southway Plaza retail/IT job expansion), and Gilman's. The Mayor also highlighted ongoing investments in parks, splash pads, and a 3-year financial commitment to MCS's "Family Navigators" social worker program.
 - **Action & Disposition:** Informational presentation only; no formal board vote required.
- **00:25:50 East Washington Academy (EWA) School Presentation & Student Spotlight**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Mrs. England (Principal) alongside EWA 5th-grade students Carter Heinemann, Amaris Anderson, and Tycho Hollow.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Principal England provided an academic and facility update for East Washington Academy, highlighting a laser-like focus on English/Language Arts (ELA) writing initiatives, the final phase of building construction/renovations (including student-created art murals and construction career pathway lessons), and high-ability programming. Three 5th-grade students shared personal experiences, favorite memories, and student-led proposals for middle school transitions (such as a tennis team and summer preview days).

- **Action & Disposition:** Informational presentation; received with board commendation.
- **00:59:38 Resolution: 2022-2023 Student and Family Handbook**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Dr. O'Neill.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Presentation of the updated 2022-2023 Student and Family Support Guide, which consolidates district handbooks and introduces a restorative practice approach to attendance (replacing purely punitive measures). Board members requested student input on specific sections (such as the dress code) before finalization, leading to an amended motion to approve the baseline guide while allowing upcoming student advisory reviews and subsequent amendments.
 - **Action & Disposition:** Approved with conditions by Voice Vote.
- **01:03:53 Financial Report**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Mr. Jerome (Chief Financial Officer).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** CFO Jerome delivered the March financial results. State basic grant revenues remain on target (~\$41.7 million projected annually), though enrollment dipped by 29 students in February. The total checkbook balance across all funds exceeded \$35.6 million (with over \$16 million in the education fund and \$12 million in the rainy day fund). The district continues paying \$50,000 monthly toward its outstanding state school loan.
 - **Action & Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote.
- **01:06:53 Computrol Software Upgrade Contract**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Mr. Jerome.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Proposal to fund a \$150,000 upgrade of the Computrol administrative and building-level accounting software to a web-based platform (migrating away from a legacy DOS green-screen system). The project will be fully funded using federal ESSER funds.
 - **Action & Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote.
- **01:08:51 Pandemic Stipend Authorization (Amendment)**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Dave Heater (Compensation Committee).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** The compensation committee recommended paying a pandemic stipend to recognize the increased challenges faced by all full-time staff and teachers. Moving beyond an initial proposal, the committee moved to double the amount to **\$2,000 per full-time employee** (with pro-rated amounts for part-time staff and mid-year hires), leveraging improved rainy day fund balances without harming district fiscal stability.
 - **Action & Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote.
- **01:13:09 Food Service Project & Kitchen Renovation Bid Award (Muncie Central High School)**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Mr. Jerome.

- **Deliberation Summary:** Seeking bids to upgrade the Muncie Central High School cafeteria kitchen area, flooring, asbestos mastic abatement, and cafeteria seating (transitioning to college-style multi-type tables). The project is funded entirely through the federal food service fund (Fund 800) spend-down plan required by the Department of Education.
 - **Action & Disposition: Approved** awarding the construction bid to CT Design and Equipment (Indianapolis, IN) for \$1,677,854.97, alongside flooring abatement contracts, by Voice Vote.
- **01:19:53 West View Elementary Renovation: Request to Advertise for Construction Manager as Constructor**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Mr. Jerome.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Request for permission to advertise for a Construction Manager as Constructor (CMc) for the upcoming West View Elementary renovation project, funded via federal ESSER funds. Legal bids will be posted April 21 and April 28, proposals received May 9, and contract award anticipated May 24.
 - **Action & Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote.
- **01:22:43 Statutory Project Hearing: Capital Improvement Projects (Muncie Central High School & Field House)**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Dr. K & Mr. Jerome.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Statutory public hearing pursuant to IC 20-26-7-37 for proposed capital improvements exceeding \$1 million financed via bonds/lease. Projects include urgent HVAC, roofing, and flooring improvements at Muncie Central High School and the 1928 Field House, as well as redesigning the 1950 concrete football stadium and track. Baker Tilley projected a total project cost of \$5.8 million (\$4.7M hard costs, \$1.1M soft costs). Because approximately \$7 million in older general obligation bonds fall off the debt schedule in 2023, the financial advisors structured the 12-year debt repayment to be **tax neutral** for local taxpayers.
 - **Public Input:** None.
 - **Action & Disposition:** Hearing closed. Subsequent votes approved **Project Resolution A** (authorizing the project and maximum cost parameters) and **Resolution B** (authorizing reimbursement of preliminary expenses prior to bond issuance) by Voice Vote.

5. Open Public Comment / Citizen Forum

- **01:24:20** *No members of the public signed up or spoke during the general public comment period.*
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6. Administrative Updates & Adjournment

- **Staff / Board Announcements:**

- Kindergarten registration opened with positive feedback regarding a simplified process; a Pre-K fair is scheduled for Thursday (4:00-6:00 PM) at the field house.
- ABC News correspondent John Quiñones recently visited West View Elementary.
- Staff transitions announced: JD Craft moving to Southside Middle School leadership, Dr. Diabel taking on a new district role, and Ronda Ward moving to the Muncie Area Career Center (MAC).
- Board members expressed well wishes for Board Chair Jim Williams during his medical recovery.

- **Adjournment:** 01:40:55 Official motion to adjourn passed by voice vote.
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